DRUGS · DRUGS THAT HARM THE EAR AND NOSE

Drug-induced rhinitis and smell loss

Many drugs block the nose, cause rhinorrhoea or damage the sense of smell. Recognising them saves patients from unnecessary investigations and operations. The commonest is rhinitis medicamentosa from decongestant sprays; others include antihypertensives, hormones, phosphodiesterase inhibitors, psychotropics, NSAIDs in aspirin-sensitive patients, cocaine, and drugs that impair smell and taste.

1 CHAPTER ONE At a glance

The drugs on one page.

1.1 Summary

DRUG-INDUCED RHINITIS AND SMELL LOSS

GROUP	EXAMPLES	EFFECT
Topical decongestants	Xylometazoline, oxymetazoline	Rebound congestion and rhinitis medicamentosa after more than 5 to 10 days
Recreational drugs	Intranasal cocaine and other drugs	Rhinitis, septal perforation, midline destruction; levamisole vasculitis
Antihypertensives	Alpha blockers (doxazosin, prazosin, tamsulosin), beta blockers, methyldopa, reserpine, ACE inhibitors (cough and sometimes rhinitis)	Nasal congestion (neurogenic, from reduced sympathetic tone)
Phosphodiesterase-5 inhibitors	Sildenafil, tadalafil	Congestion (vasodilatation)
Hormones	Oestrogens, combined oral contraceptive pill, pregnancy itself	Congestion

GROUP	EXAMPLES	EFFECT
NSAIDs and aspirin	All COX-1 inhibitors	Rhinorrhoea, congestion and asthma in aspirin-exacerbated respiratory disease
Psychotropics	Chlorpromazine, risperidone, amitriptyline, gabapentin	Congestion
Smell and taste loss	Intranasal zinc gluconate (anosmia), terbinafine, ACE inhibitors, metronidazole, clarithromycin, chemotherapy, radiotherapy	Hyposmia, anosmia, dysgeusia

2 CHAPTER TWO Using it in ENT

Practice.

2.1 Taking a drug history

In every patient with nasal obstruction or smell loss, ask about prescribed, over-the-counter and recreational drugs and sprays. Stopping or changing the drug, where possible, often resolves symptoms; treat rhinitis medicamentosa with a nasal steroid while the decongestant is withdrawn.

2.2 Smell loss

Most drug-related smell and taste disturbance is reversible on stopping the drug, but zinc nasal sprays have caused permanent anosmia. Olfactory training helps recovery from many causes of smell loss.

3 CHAPTER THREE For the examination

What the examiner wants to hear.

3.1 Viva essentials

WHAT THE EXAMINER IS LOOKING FOR

- Mechanism and treatment of **rhinitis medicamentosa**.
- Drugs that cause nasal congestion and smell loss.
- Cocaine-induced midline destructive lesions.

3.2 Common pitfalls

COMMON PITFALLS

- Turbinate surgery for congestion caused by a decongestant spray or an alpha blocker.

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